

Comparative Analysis of Three National League Aces

Ohtani, Sanchez, and Misorowski — 2026 Season

This report analyzes Statcast pitch-by-pitch data for three elite NL pitchers in the 2026 season. The goal is to evaluate whether Shohei Ohtani's pitching performance is genuinely superior to that of Cristopher Sanchez and Jacob Misorowski.

1. Data Overview

The dataset contains 4,797 total pitch events. Ohtani has thrown 1,335 pitches across 14 games, Sanchez 1,800 pitches in 19 games, and Misorowski 1,662 pitches in 18 games. Ohtani's reduced workload is immediately notable; he has pitched approximately 35% fewer pitches than Sanchez.

2. Pitch Arsenal Analysis

Ohtani deploys the widest arsenal (7 pitch types), but variety does not equate to superiority. Sanchez uses only 3 pitch types (sinker, changeup, slider) yet achieves elite results through sheer command and deception. Misorowski relies heavily on a dominant four-seam fastball (63.1% usage) averaging 100.5 mph.

Metric	Ohtani	Sanchez	Misorowski
Primary FB Velo	98.1 mph (FF)	95.2 mph (SI)	100.5 mph (FF)
Max Velocity	101.7 mph	97.7 mph	105.5 mph
Whiff% (Best Pitch)	37.1% (ST)	42.7% (SL)	43.6% (CU)

Ohtani's best whiff pitch (sweeper, 37.1%) is outperformed by both Sanchez's slider (42.7%) and changeup (42.0%), as well as Misorowski's curveball (43.6%). Overall whiff rates tell the same story: Ohtani (28.4%) trails Sanchez (29.7%) and Misorowski (34.3%).

3. Plate Discipline and Control

The most significant gap between Ohtani and Sanchez is in command. Ohtani's walk rate of 7.6% is the highest among the three and nearly 60% higher than Sanchez's elite 4.8%. This directly impacts run prevention, as free baserunners increase scoring opportunities.

Metric	Ohtani	Sanchez	Misorowski
K%	27.9%	27.6%	39.6%
BB%	7.6%	4.8%	6.4%
K-BB%	20.3%	22.8%	33.2%

4. Run Expectancy Impact

The run expectancy delta (delta_pitcher_run_exp) directly measures how much each pitcher changes the expected runs on each pitch. A lower (more negative) value is better.

Sanchez (+14.487 total, +0.0080 per pitch) has been significantly better at preventing runs than Ohtani (+21.028 total, +0.0158 per pitch). This is despite Sanchez throwing 465 more pitches. On a per-pitch basis, Sanchez gives up less than half the run value of Ohtani. This is a decisive finding.

5. Platoon Splits

Ohtani struggles against left-handed batters (.545 OPS allowed) compared to Sanchez (.336) and Misorowski (.288). Sanchez's 36.2% K% and 1.7% BB% against LHB are truly elite. While Ohtani handles RHB well (.383 OPS), his overall platoon profile is less dominant than his peers.

6. Conclusion

The data does not support the claim that Shohei Ohtani has been the best pitcher among these three NL aces in 2026.

Cristopher Sanchez has demonstrated superior command (4.8% BB%), better run prevention per pitch (+0.0080 RE delta), and a more effective pitch mix despite using only 3 pitch types. His sinker-changeup combination generates extreme ground ball tendencies (192 ground balls) and elite whiff rates on his secondary offerings (42.7% on slider, 42.0% on changeup).

Jacob Misorowski has been the most dominant in terms of raw stuff, with a 39.6% K%, 34.3% whiff rate, and 54.6% strike rate that place him in a separate tier. His 100.5 mph fastball with elite secondary pitches makes him arguably the hardest pitcher to face in the NL.

Ohtani remains an excellent pitcher — his contact suppression (zero barrels, 86.9 mph avg exit velocity) and expected stats are genuinely strong. However, his elevated walk rate, lower whiff rates, and significantly worse run expectancy impact suggest that his 2026 pitching performance has been outperformed by Sanchez and Misorowski in the areas that matter most for run prevention.